

been friends forever. It was perhaps the fear of the rampaging elephant's rage in Uttar Pradesh which brought the two together. After all, Mayawati is the Queen. She had made it clear that she'd brook no challenge when she had Congress workers arrested

cept the leadership of a third front which collapsed even before it could take off.

But her dreams didn't crash. The queen of social engineering steamed on the belief that, as in the past, the front would revive and, in a fractured polity, even come to power and she would get to fulfil her ambition of becoming prime minister. Egged on by her own astounding victory in Uttar Pradesh last year, she took her leadership of the non-existent front seriously, putting up candidates wherever elections were held. There were also fringe players like Ajit Singh, always on the lookout for a safe haven. Having joined the Third Front, Singh lived up to his reputation, flirted with the BJP to save his western Uttar Pradesh bastion from falling to Mayawati or Mulayam.

Politicians experience fear only if they have tasted power, or as in the case of Prakash Karat, wielded it. Manmohan had the last laugh by winning a trust vote that everyone thought he would lose. In the end, Karat was left nursing a bruised ego though after Nandigram, Singur and Munnar, he should be living in dread of more serious setbacks. Faced with the real question of the Left losing its dominant status in the next Lok Sabha, the dogmatic Karat, a man who this magazine called "Full Marx" in its Newsmakers 2007, forged alliances with Mayawati and Jayalalithaa, both of whom thrive on a combination of high living and pragmatic thinking. For the Congress, for every Karat that walks out, there is a Mamata Banerjee ready for a homecoming. For the once

feisty Trinamool Congress leader, the elections to the 15th Lok Sabha give her perhaps the last chance to fulfil the potential that she showed when she broke away from the Congress.

The abundance of fear affected the BJP whose leadership was rushing into compromises. Rajasthan and Delhi are states it should have won with the right strategy. However, fears that any punishment meted out would invite retribution in the form of internal sabotage to damage the prime ministerial prospects of L.K. Advani is keeping its partymen from fixing accountability for the defeats. While the Congress is thrusting more responsibilities on its 3G leaders, the BJP's GenNext line-up just about makes it to the right side of 60. All talk of inducting Narendra Modi to join the Advani-Rajnath duo in the party's Lok Sabha campaign have been nipped by those who fear reading their political obituaries.

Fear will continue to dominate the consciousness of the political classes for a while in 2009. With democratic institutions collapsing, small rulers with big egos who don't like to be questioned will continue to dictate the agenda. It's this intolerance that allows a 20-year-old from a poverty-stricken village across the border to sneak into India's financial capital and make a nation of over a billion people look like an orphaned state. While the killers were on a murderous spree, our leaders debated for ever but never showed a readiness to hit back, crippled as they were by the fear of exposing their impotence.



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and worse, didn't allow the Gandhi parivar to enter their fiefdoms of Amethi and Rae Bareilly. Mulayam Singh Yadav, Amar Singh and Sonia shared the same predicament in Uttar Pradesh. The kind that turns an enemy's enemies into friends.

Spare a thought for Behenji. She too lives in constant fear of elimination, both physically and politically. It was the first that saw her making noises about withdrawal of support if she wasn't given cover of the Special Protection Group (SPG). That was beyond the SPG charter which says only current and former prime ministers besides the Gandhi parivar are eligible. With none of her partners from her past political marriages ready to walk down the aisle with her again, she chose to ac-

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